FIGURE 9.2 The geographic spread of the Indian Ocean, with India's Andaman and Nicobar Islands
Source: Author.

India and the United States in the Indo-Pacific

For the United States, the Asia-Pacific has always been important. Changes in the world since the end of the Cold War, including an unprecedented geo-economic shift of commerce and wealth to Asia, and in particular East Asia, have further increased US attention to the region. Unrelenting economic growth in Asia, driven first by Japan, followed by Korea, Taiwan, Hong Kong, and Singapore, then by China, now also includes India. India's economic expansion, and its will to power demonstrated by the 1998 nuclear weapons tests – which the United States at the time did its best to prevent – have gradually changed the dynamic of the Indo–US relationship.[27] In his 2018 Shangri-La Dialogue speech in Singapore, Prime Minister Modi spoke with particular warmth about India's global strategic partnership with the United States, with which India has finally overcome "the hesitations of history," and about the extraordinary breadth of the Indo–US relationship.[28]

The Strategic Vision Document on the Indian Ocean and Asia-Pacific, agreed to during President Obama's visit to India in 2015, is generally regarded as a forthright commitment on the part of India and the United States to work together on a range of security issues in the Indo-Pacific theatre, including managing the rise of China.[29] The document refers to accelerating infrastructure connectivity between South, Southeast, and Central Asia; ensuring freedom of navigation, especially in the South China Sea; avoiding the use or threat of force in dispute settlement; and strengthening the East